

An aerial photograph of a residential neighborhood in Wellington, New Zealand. The foreground shows several houses with various roof colors (blue, red, grey). A prominent yellow house with a dark roof is visible. The middle ground is filled with more houses and trees. In the background, a large hill (Mt. Wellington) is visible under a clear blue sky.

REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Wellington

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Wellington.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Wellington

Wellington Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Whanganui-a-Tara. If you're reading this you're somewhere between curious and committed. Either is a good place to be, and this guide is written for both.

A city small enough to belong to quickly



Oriental Bay. The hills come down to the water, which is why the city never sprawled

Wellington is the smallest capital most people have lived in, and that's the whole character of the place. It has a tertiary hospital, a parliament, a national museum, a theatre scene and a working port — all inside a city you can walk across in an afternoon.

The effect on a newcomer is unusual. You'll run into the same people. Your registrar will know your neighbour. Within two months you'll have a coffee place where they start your order when you walk in. In a bigger city that takes years, and for a lot of people moving countries alone, it's the thing that makes the move survivable.

The same smallness is why some people leave. Fewer specialists, less anonymity, and a professional world where your reputation travels fast. We'll be straight about all of that as we go.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Where we think Wellington is the wrong answer for someone, we say so. That's more useful to you and, honestly, better for us than a placement that doesn't last.

The city, in nine numbers

Not a fact sheet. These are the nine figures that actually shape a week here.

8 km

Across at its widest. The whole city, hills to harbour.

~215,000

People in the city, around 440,000 across the wider region.

15 min

A typical commute. The single biggest lifestyle variable between NZ cities.

Same

Clinical pay as Auckland – national collective agreements, lower housing costs.

1 tertiary hospital

Serving the lower North Island and the top of the South.

20 min

From most suburbs to a hill track or the south coast.

12–20°

The usual range. Rarely freezing, rarely hot, never still for long.

2 flights

To reach Europe. The runway is short, so long-haul means a connection.

One coffee

Per capita, more cafés than almost anywhere. It isn't a boast, it's a fact of the street.

Six things you only learn by living here

Small, specific, and the sort of thing that makes the first month feel less foreign if you know it in advance.

Nobody uses an umbrella

The wind turns them inside out within a fortnight and you'll feel conspicuous carrying one. Buy a proper hooded rain jacket before you arrive – the single most useful thing in a Wellington wardrobe.

The southerly is a forecast, not a mood

People will say "there's a southerly coming" and mean it practically – flights, the ferry, whether the barbecue happens. Learn the difference between a northerly (warm, blustery) and a southerly (cold, straight off Antarctica) in your first week.

Everyone works in government, sort of

At a party you'll meet policy analysts, select committee staff and ministry advisors. Politics is discussed the way sport is elsewhere, and it's entirely normal to see a minister buying coffee.

Houses have heat pumps, not heating

Central heating is rare. A heat pump in the living room and nothing in the bedrooms is standard, so bedrooms get cold. A dehumidifier is a normal appliance here, not a sign something is wrong.

The city walks

Far more people walk to work than in any other New Zealand city. Good shoes matter more than a good car.

Earthquakes are ordinary

You'll feel one. Buildings are engineered for it, everyone has a plan, and the fuss is much smaller than you'd expect. Sort your grab bag in week one and then stop thinking about it.

A note on te reo

Te Whanganui-a-Tara is Wellington's name in te reo Māori – the great harbour of Tara. You'll see and hear both, and increasingly the Māori name first in official use.

You're not expected to arrive fluent. You are expected to try. [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation and the words you'll hear on the ward.

Why Wellington

Wellington Guide · Chapter 2 of 9



The case for the capital comes down to one number: twenty minutes. What you do with the hours that buys you is the actual argument.

Small is the feature, not the compromise

Wellington is hemmed in by hills on one side and the harbour on the other, which means it never sprawled. The city that resulted is roughly eight kilometres across at its widest, with a tertiary hospital, a university campus, the seat of government, a theatre district and a working port all inside that.

The consequence for you is arithmetic. A thirty-five-minute commute each way, five days a week, is roughly six hours. Fifteen minutes each way is two and a half. That difference — most of a working day, every week — is the single largest lifestyle variable between New Zealand cities, and it compounds over years.

The Beehive: Parliament, in a city small enough to walk across

THE ARITHMETIC OF TWENTY MINUTES

Hours spent commuting in a five-day week, at true relative scale. The difference is most of a working day – every week, for as long as you stay.



Roughly a working month a year. What you do with it is the actual argument for the capital – the week below is one shape it tends to take.

8 km

Across, at the widest

3.5 hrs

A week, saved against a big-city commute

20 min

From most suburbs to a hill track

Same

Salary as Auckland – national agreements

The same pay, a smaller outgoing

- Because clinical pay sits on national collective agreements, your salary here is identical to what it would be in Auckland – while housing costs meaningfully less.
- That gap is the quiet financial case for Wellington, and it doesn't appear on any job advertisement. **Money, tax & banking** works through what actually lands in your account.

What twenty minutes actually buys

One clinician's week, in the shape it tends to take here. Not a promise – an illustration of what becomes possible when the commute stops eating the evening.

Monday

Walk to work along the waterfront. Home by six, and the evening is still an evening.

Tuesday

Late finish, but the drive home is fifteen minutes and there's no motorway in it.

Wednesday

Football or a hill run straight from the office. The trailhead is inside the city.

Thursday

Theatre, a gig or a talk. A small city with a capital's cultural calendar.

Friday

Cuba Street, and the walk home takes twenty minutes past the harbour.

Weekend

The south coast, the Wairarapa or a ferry to the Sounds. All of it inside two hours.

The six things people ask us

Is the clinical work as good as Auckland's?

How bad is the wind, honestly?

What about the earthquake risk?

Can I really live without a car?

Is it expensive?

Is it good with children?

What we'd ask you to weigh

Every one of these is a real reason people leave. Read them properly — it's cheaper to decide against Wellington now than in eighteen months.

The wind is genuinely relentless

Not a quirky local detail. Wellington sits in a strait that funnels southerlies and northerlies through the city, and gusts over a hundred kilometres an hour arrive several times a year.

Flights get cancelled, the ferry stops, and umbrellas are pointless. People either stop noticing within a year or never stop resenting it, and you can't tell which you'll be until you live here.

Cold, damp housing

Much of the stock is old timber on a hillside, built for a climate nobody actually has. Winter interiors can be unpleasant, and mould is a common complaint rather than an unlucky one.

Healthy Homes standards set a floor, not a good outcome — view in winter if you can.

A smaller professional world

Fewer specialists in your field, fewer people to learn from, and fewer options if you want to change roles without changing city. In the narrowest subspecialties there may be two or three people in the country doing what you do. If your career plan needs a large department to move around inside, Auckland is the more honest answer.

Long-haul means a connection

The runway is short, so international flights are limited to Australia and the Pacific. Everything else goes via Auckland or Sydney, which adds hours and a transfer to every trip home.

Earthquake risk is real

Wellington sits on a fault line and everyone knows it. Buildings are engineered for it and the practical risk to you is low, but if the idea keeps you awake, be honest about that now.

Weighing Wellington against Auckland or somewhere smaller is a sensible thing to do properly. Our [New Zealand destination guides](#) cover each region just as honestly.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you need the largest system in the country, [Auckland](#) carries more sites and deeper sub-specialty cover.

If the wind and the seismic question weigh on you honestly, [Hawke's Bay](#) and [Nelson Tasman](#) are calmer in both senses.

If you want materially more house for the money within reach of the capital, [Palmerston North](#) is two hours north.

In our experience

Wellington suits clinicians who want a capital's culture without a capital's commute — twenty minutes door to door buys back a working month every year, and the city fills it well. Respect the wind, rent before you buy, and it's the easiest big small city in the country.

Wellington at a glance

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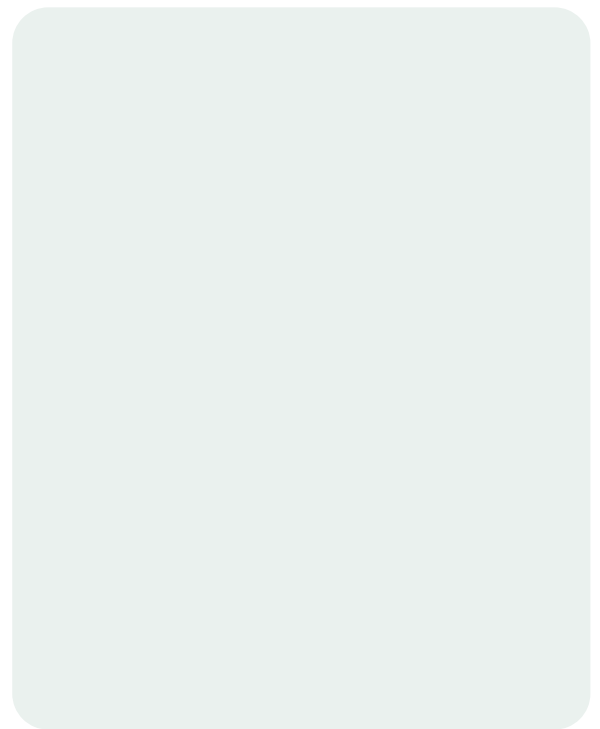


A harbour in a drowned river valley, ringed by hills, sitting on a plate boundary at the windiest point in the country. The geography explains almost everything about this city.

Everything here is explained by the hills and the strait

Wellington sits at the southern tip of the North Island, on a harbour formed when a river valley flooded. Steep hills rise directly from the water on three sides, and Cook Strait — a forty-kilometre gap between two mountainous islands — opens to the south.

That single arrangement produces the compact walkable centre, the houses stacked up hillsides with a hundred steps to the door, the absence of motorways through town, the four rail lines threading up the only flat corridors, and the wind. Understand the geography and the rest of this guide reads as consequence.



Where Wellington sits, with the straight-line distance to Masterton

The harbour A deep natural port that made the city and still runs it. Oriental Bay for swimming, the waterfront promenade for walking, Matiu / Somes Island in the middle.

The town belt A ring of protected bush and open land encircling the inner city, set aside in the 1840s. It's why a capital city has native forest fifteen minutes from most front doors.

The south coast Wild, exposed and facing Antarctica. Lyall Bay for surf, Island Bay for families, Red Rocks for a seal colony an hour's walk from the road end.

Two valleys north The Hutt Valley and the western corridor to Porirua – the only flat land in the region, which is where the rail lines, the motorways and most of the family housing went.

"Wellington" means four quite different places

People say Wellington and mean the city. The region is larger, and which part you live in changes your rent, your commute and your weekends considerably.

FOUR WELLINGTONS, BY HOW FAR THEY ARE FROM WORK

Same salary in all four. What changes is your rent, your commute and what you do on a Saturday – which is the whole decision, compressed into one chart.

Wellington City

The compact centre and the hill suburbs around it.

Walkable, characterful, the highest rents in the region.

Suits people who want to walk to work.



10 min

The Hutt Valley

Lower and Upper Hutt, by train. Flat land, family

houses, gardens, considerably better value, and its own hospital. Suits families who want space.



20 – 40 min

Porirua & the western corridor

North by rail. Diverse, well-served by trains, strong

Pacific and Māori communities, and among the best value in the region.



25 min

Kāpiti Coast

Beaches, a slower pace and a genuine commuter rail line. Suits people trading commute for coastline.



45 – 60 min

Rail and road times to the central city at peak. Off-peak is quicker; a southerly is not.

Mild, changeable, and windier than anywhere you've lived

The temperature range here is narrow. Winters rarely freeze and summers rarely get properly hot – a mean around thirteen degrees, and a good summer day in the low twenties. If you're coming from northern Europe the winters will feel mild; from the Middle East or India, the summers will feel cool.

The wind is the real story. Cook Strait funnels air between two mountain ranges, and Wellington sits in the gap.

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DAYS A YEAR

see gusts above sixty-three kilometres an hour. It isn't constant – there are still, golden days that are among the best anywhere – but it's frequent enough to shape how people dress, where they park and which side of the harbour they choose to live on.

Two winds to learn

The northerly is warm, blustery and persistent.

The southerly comes off Antarctica, drops the temperature several degrees within an hour, and closes the airport.

Locals check which one is coming the way people elsewhere check rain.

Summer

DEC – FEB

The best of it. Long evenings, swimming at Oriental Bay, and the northerly rather than the southerly. Still not reliably hot – bring a jumper to a January barbecue.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

Often the finest weather of the year – settled, warm, calmer than summer. Locals will tell you autumn is when Wellington is at its best, and they're right.

Winter

JUN – AUG

Wet, windy and dark by half past five. The houses matter more than the forecast – see [Renting in New Zealand](#) for what to check at a viewing.

Spring

SEP – NOV

Changeable and blustery, with the first properly good days arriving in October. Spring here is a negotiation rather than a season.

A mean around thirteen degrees, and a good summer day in the low twenties. From northern Europe the winters will feel mild; from the Middle East or India, the summers will feel cool.

The fault line, plainly

Wellington sits on a plate boundary and everyone knows it. You'll feel small earthquakes; most people stop noticing within a year.

What that means in practice

Buildings are engineered for it, and the standards are among the strictest anywhere. Newer and strengthened buildings are genuinely safe.

Ask about a building's seismic rating when you rent or buy – it's a normal question here, not a rude one. Sort a grab bag and stored water in week one, then stop thinking about it. That's what locals do.

Whose place this is

Te Whanganui-a-Tara – the great harbour of Tara. Taranaki Whānui and Ngāti Toa Rangatira are the mana whenua of the region, and both are visible in the city's institutions, place names and the way the health service works.

You'll hear te reo daily, in meetings and on signage. What that means at work – pronunciation, the words you'll hear on the ward, Te Tiriti and marae etiquette – is national, and covered in [Te ao Māori at work](#).

Healthcare in Wellington

Wellington Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



A tertiary hospital serving the lower half of the North Island, ten minutes from the harbour — and the national health bodies down the road.

How the New Zealand system is funded and organised nationally is covered in [How the health system works](#). This chapter is Wellington specifically.

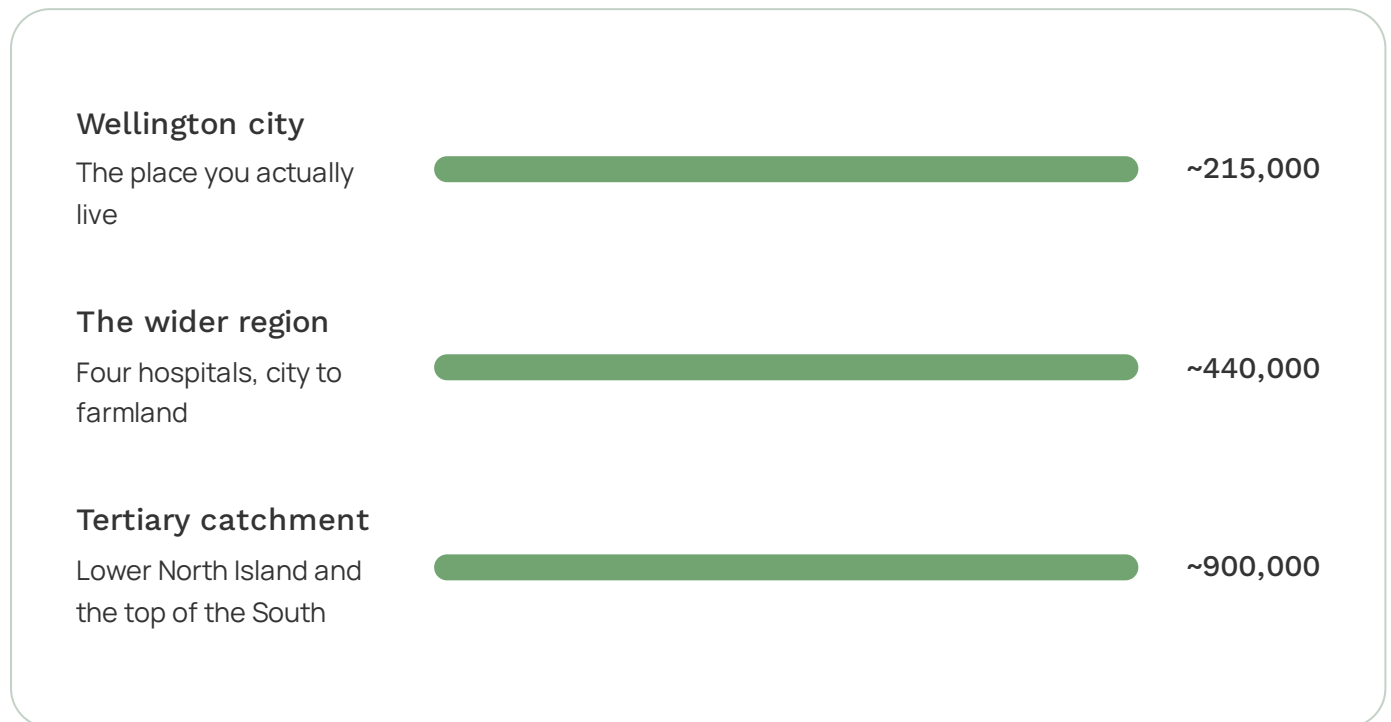
A small city doing tertiary work for a large region

This is the thing that surprises clinicians most about Wellington. The city is modest — around 215,000 people, 440,000 across the region — but the region's tertiary hospital serves the lower North Island and parts of the upper South Island, a catchment of roughly nine hundred thousand.

The practical effect is a case mix considerably more complex than the population suggests, delivered by teams considerably smaller than you'd find in Auckland. You get subspecialty exposure with the intimacy of a district hospital, which is either the ideal combination or an uncomfortable stretch depending on how you like to work.

WHY THE CASE MIX OUTFRONS THE CITY

Three numbers, at true relative scale. The hospital is sized for the third one, the city you live in is the first – and that gap is the whole character of clinical work here.



Catchment is the population the tertiary hospital serves for tertiary care, not the number of people living in the city.

~900k

Tertiary catchment, across two islands

4

Public hospitals across the region

10 min

From the CBD to the regional hospital

2

Universities with health campuses in the city

Retrieval is part of the job here

Patients arrive from Wairarapa, Whanganui, Palmerston North, Nelson and Blenheim – some by road, some by air.

Air ambulance and retrieval work is routine rather than exceptional, and if that interests you, Wellington is one of the better places in the country to do it.

The four public hospitals

Four public hospitals serve the greater Wellington region. Which one you join shapes your commute, your caseload and how far you live from the city.

THE FOUR HOSPITALS, NORTH TO SOUTH

They sit along one line of geography – up the western corridor, through the city, out along the valley and over the hill. Where you join decides which end of it you live at.

A community hospital

Porirua, twenty-five minutes north · day surgery, maternity, outpatients and community services for the northern suburbs and the western corridor

The tertiary centre

Newtown, ten minutes from the CBD · intensive care, cardiothoracic, neurosurgery, oncology, a children's hospital and the region's emergency department

A busy secondary hospital

Lower Hutt, about twenty-five minutes from the city · serving the valley, with its own emergency department and a strong reputation for burns and plastics

A rural hospital

Masterton, over the Remutaka Hill · serving a wide farming catchment – broad generalist work, and a very different pace from Newtown

Most inner suburbs are a short commute to Newtown; the valley, the north and the Wairarapa each pull your search in a different direction. [Where clinicians live](#) reorders every suburb by the hospital you pick.

A private sector that's easier to move within

Wellington's private sector is compact – a handful of hospitals doing planned surgery, endoscopy, diagnostics and day procedures, funded by insurance, by ACC, by patients directly and increasingly by Health New Zealand outsourcing elective lists.

Because everything is close together, working across both sectors is unusually practical. A public list in Newtown in the morning and a private list nearby in the afternoon is a short drive, not a cross-town expedition.

For theatre nurses, anaesthetic technicians, radiographers and sonographers, the private hospitals are a substantial employer in their own right – and generally offer more regular hours than a tertiary roster.

Newtown

The largest private hospital in the region sits close to the regional hospital, which makes cross-sector work about as convenient as it gets anywhere in the country.

Crofton Downs

Surgical and medical private care on the north-western side of the city, close to Karori, Khandallah and the Johnsonville line suburbs.

Across the region

Day-stay, endoscopy and imaging facilities, alongside community radiology networks with clinics through the city, the Hutt Valley and Porirua.

A landscape sketch, not a directory – sites and ownership change.

Beyond the wards

Hospitals are the obvious employer. Three more account for a great deal of the clinical work in the region.

Primary care

General practices grouped into Primary Health Organisations, plus after-hours accident and medical clinics. GPs here are independent businesses rather than hospital employees.

Community radiology

Clinics through the city, the Hutt and Porirua running their own MRI, CT, ultrasound and mammography. Often more regular hours than a hospital roster.

National bodies

Being the capital means Health New Zealand's national office, the Ministry of Health, Pharmac and Te Aho o Te Kahu are all here. If policy, quality or research interests you, no other city comes close.

What's different here

A SMALL CLINICAL WORLD, BOTH WAYS

Almost everything clinicians tell us about working in Wellington traces back to one fact: the teams are small. That is the appeal and the cost, and it is worth reading both columns before you decide.

What you gain

You'll know everyone

Within a month you'll know the consultants, the radiographers and the ward clerks by name. Decisions happen in corridors.

Retrieval and telehealth are routine

Geography is part of clinical practice when your catchment crosses a strait – both are everyday work here rather than exceptional, and if that interests you, few places do more of it.

Policy is next door

The people writing the guidelines are in the same city, often the same room. Unusually easy to get involved.

You can walk to work

More Wellington clinicians walk or bus to work than anywhere else in New Zealand. It changes the shape of the day.

What you trade

Your reputation travels fast

A small professional world cuts both ways. Good work is noticed quickly; so is the other kind.

Fewer subspecialists

In the narrowest fields there may be two or three people in the country doing what you do. Excellent for autonomy, harder for peer support.

Smaller teams, tertiary load

The case mix is a nine-hundred-thousand catchment; the rota is a city of two hundred thousand. Ask how the on-call is actually staffed.

What ACC covers, how enrolment works and what everyday care costs are national – see [How the health system works](#).

A note on names

We don't name hospitals, trusts or private providers as places of work anywhere on this site – a named employer implies a relationship, and the post and the package get confirmed with you directly.

Where a public body is named on this page, it is there as a **reference point** for how the system is organised. It is not an employer reference, and it does not imply we recruit for it.

Where clinicians live

Wellington Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



Fourteen suburbs, sorted by commute to whichever hospital you'll work at. In Wellington the variables are unusual: sun, wind exposure and how many steps to your front door.

Three questions, in this order

Settle these before you look at a single listing. In a city this small, getting the order right saves you from a lease you regret.

One · Which hospital?

Everything follows from this. Newtown for the regional hospital, the valley for Hutt, the northern suburbs for Kenepuru, over the hill for Wairarapa. Wellington is small but the harbour and the hills make some journeys much longer than the map suggests.

Two · Car, train, or on foot?

If you want to be car-free you need an inner suburb or a rail line — those are genuinely different sets of suburbs. If you're driving, off-street parking becomes the thing you fight for, and many older houses simply don't have it.

Three · Sun or space?

The Wellington trade nobody warns you about. North-facing, sunny and sheltered costs a premium and the houses are smaller. South-facing or wind-exposed gets you more room for less money, and a much colder winter.

Rent for a year before you commit to a suburb

Wellington's microclimates vary street by street in a way that's hard to believe until you live it. One valley is still and sunny; the next ridge is in cloud and wind.

A year of renting tells you which side of the hill you actually want. [Renting in New Zealand](#) covers the application pack and the bond.

Pick your hospital, then read down

Suburbs reorder by commute to whichever hospital you select. Rents are indicative weekly figures for a three-bedroom house as at July 2026 — treat them as a shape, not a quote.



Character homes on the hill – and the steps that come with them

Commuting to

Show

Commutes are typical door-to-door driving times outside peak, and Wellington peak adds meaningfully to the longer ones. Rents move – check current listings before budgeting.

The three things that decide a Wellington house

Anywhere else you look at bedrooms, schools and the commute. Here those matter too, but three local variables will affect your daily life more, and none of them appear on a listing in any useful form. Locals assess a house on these before they look at the kitchen. It takes newcomers about one winter to understand why.

Which way it faces

North-facing is the single most valuable feature a Wellington house can have. Winter sun into the living room, a dry interior and a heating bill you can live with. South-facing on a hillside can mean no direct sun for months. Visit at eleven in the morning in winter if you possibly can – a photograph taken in January tells you nothing.

How exposed it is

Ridge tops and the south coast take the full force of the southerly. A sheltered valley three hundred metres away can be a different climate entirely. Ask which way the prevailing wind hits, and stand outside for ten minutes before you decide.

How many steps

Houses on the hills are reached by staircases – sometimes a hundred or more from the street. Charming at a viewing, less so with shopping, a pram, or after a night shift. Count them, and be honest about the next ten years.

How renting works nationally – applications, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is the same everywhere, and set out in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

Cost of living

Wellington Guide · Chapter 7 of 9

Same salary as Auckland, meaningfully lower rent — and one bill that will surprise you in July.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Wellington against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

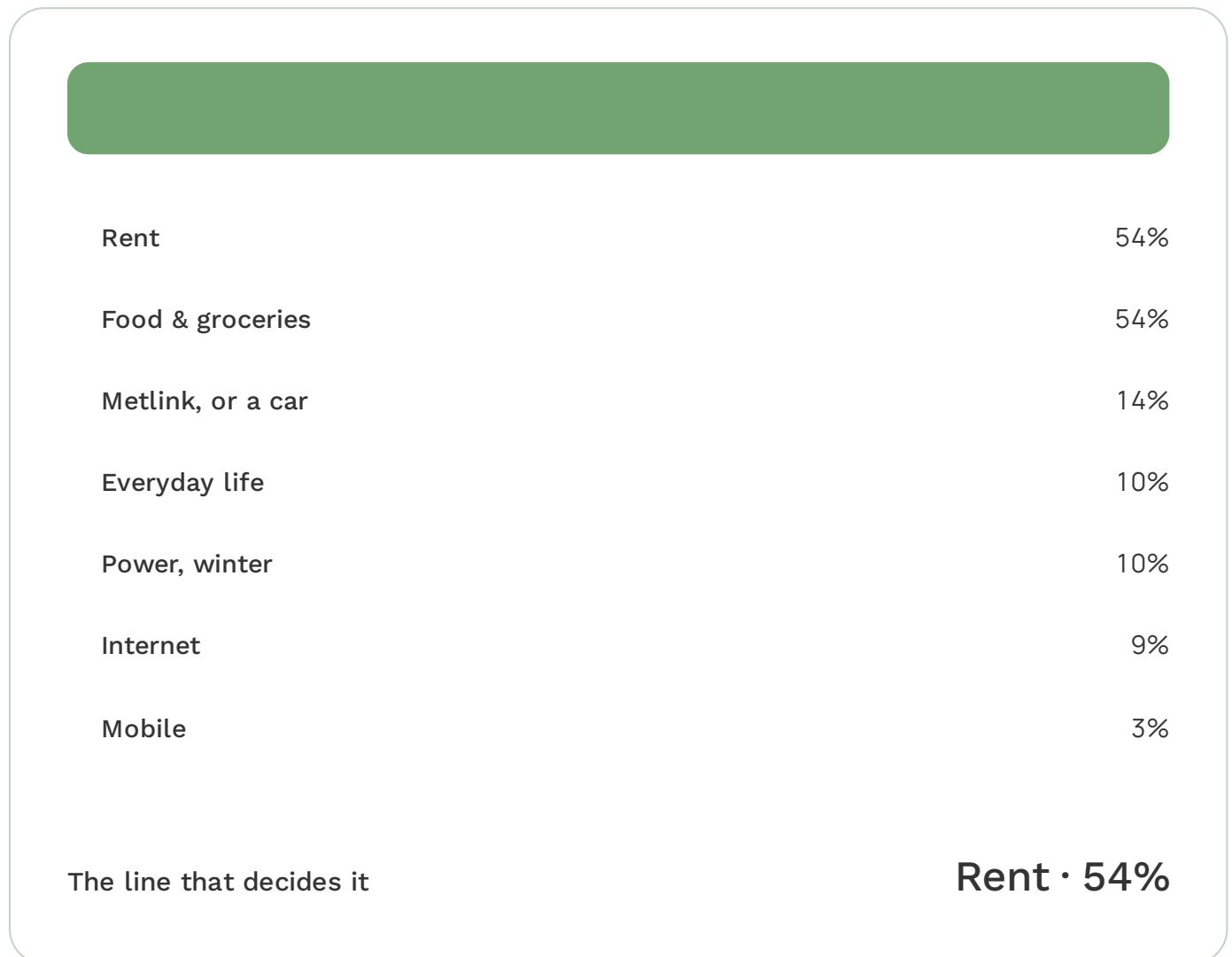
Because clinical pay sits on national collective agreements, your gross salary here is identical to Auckland's. Housing costs less. That gap is the quiet financial case for Wellington, and it doesn't appear on any job advertisement.

What a month costs

Indicative New Zealand dollars per month as at July 2026, for a household living moderately. Your own numbers will differ — treat this as a shape to sanity-check against, not a quote.

SINGLE CLINICIAN, INNER SUBURB

Rent is over half of it. Everything else put together is smaller than the roof over your head – which is exactly why the Wellington rent gap matters more than any other line here.



Bar widths are proportions of the month, not amounts. In summer the power line roughly halves, and the whole month eases with it.

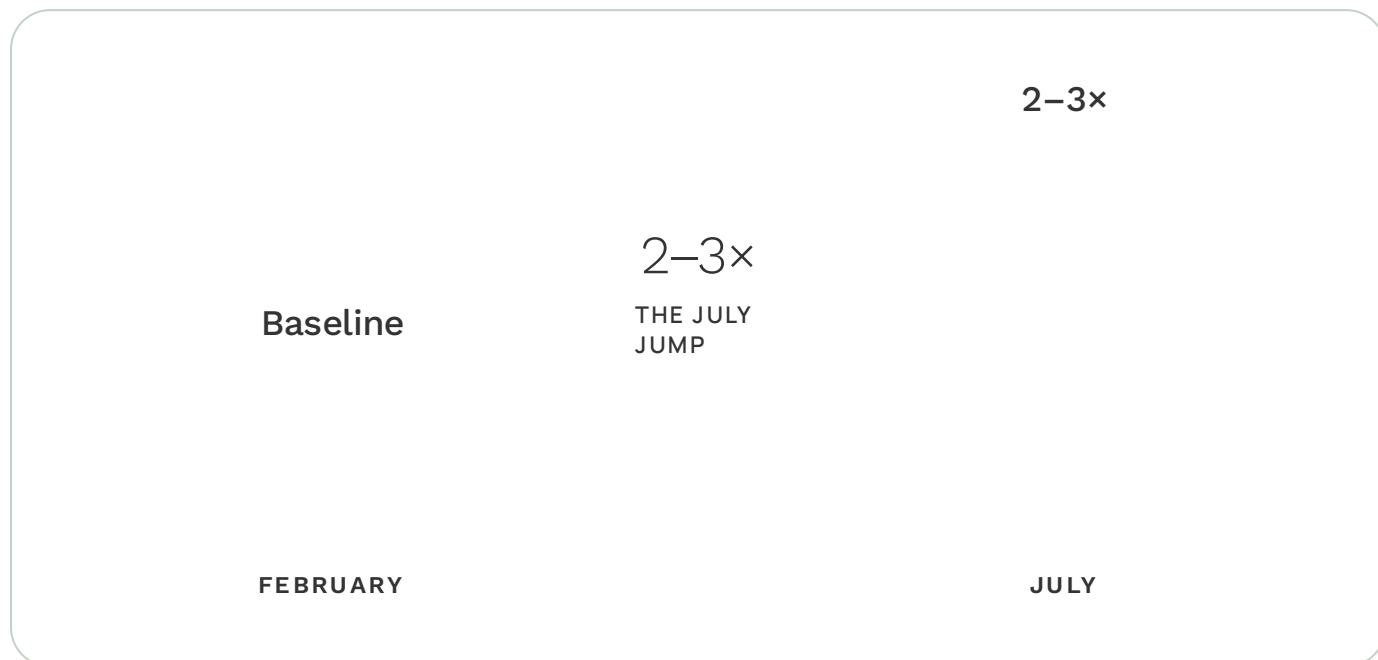
Excludes tax, KiwiSaver, student loan repayments, a deposit and flights home. [Money, tax & banking](#) works out what actually lands in your account – put the two together for a real answer.

The one bill that catches everyone out

Your power bill in July can be two or three times what it was in February. This isn't a New Zealand pricing quirk – it's what happens when a poorly insulated timber house meets a cold, damp winter and a heat pump running most of the day.

People arriving in summer sign a lease based on a February bill, then get a July one and think something has gone wrong. Nothing has. Budget for the winter figure from the start and treat the summer months as the discount.

THE SAME HOUSE, SIX MONTHS APART



Column heights are to scale, using the midpoint of each range. A well-insulated house narrows the gap considerably – which is the whole argument for the checklist below.

Five ways to keep it down

Prioritise insulation and double glazing when you choose a house, above almost every other feature. It's worth more than a second bathroom.

Ask for the Healthy Homes compliance statement on any rental – landlords must meet minimum heating and insulation standards.

Buy a dehumidifier in your first month. It costs less to run than heating damp air, and it protects your belongings from mould.

Compare retailers properly – the market is competitive and switching is easy. Powerswitch is the free comparison tool people use.

Heat the room you're in and shut the door. Whole-house heating is rare and expensive here.

Setting up costs

Unfurnished here can mean genuinely empty – no fridge, no washing machine, sometimes no curtains. Budget for the first fortnight properly.

WHAT THE FIRST FORTNIGHT COSTS

Bars are to scale against each other, so you can see where the money actually goes before you've bought a kettle.

Bond & rent in advance

Four weeks' bond plus two weeks' rent, up front. The single largest thing to have ready.



1x

Whiteware

Fridge, washing machine, sometimes a dryer. Second-hand from Trade Me is normal and unsnobbish.



~0.4x

Heating & drying

A dehumidifier and a decent heater. In Wellington these aren't optional.



~0.1x

Then a car, if you need one — reliable is affordable here, thanks to the used Japanese import market. It sits off this scale because it dwarfs every thing else on it. See [Driving & licences](#).

Cheaper than Auckland, and where it shows

Where it shows

Rent

The big one. A three-bedroom house in a good Wellington suburb costs meaningfully less than the Auckland equivalent, on identical pay.

Commuting

Shorter distances, less fuel, and a genuine option to run one car instead of two.

Parking & tolls

No motorway tolls, and if you walk to work the whole line disappears.

Where it doesn't

Power in winter

The one line where Wellington costs more than Auckland, and the one people forget.

Flights

Every long-haul trip carries a connection through Auckland or Sydney. Budget it honestly.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Numbeo cost-of-living calculator (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) — the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

Expatistan (<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>) — the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

Tenancy Services market rent (<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>) — official bond-lodgement data by area, and the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

Stats NZ (<https://www.stats.govt.nz/>) — official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Getting around

Wellington Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

The only New Zealand city where "do I need a car?" has a interesting answer. Four rail lines, a cable car, a harbour ferry, and a walkable centre.

Converting your licence, buying a car, a warrant of fitness and registration are all in [Driving & licences](#). This chapter is about moving around Wellington specifically.

Probably not for work. Probably yes for weekends.

This is the honest answer and it holds for most clinicians here. If you live in an inner suburb or on a rail line, getting to work without a car is straightforward and often faster than driving. Plenty of Wellington staff genuinely don't own one.

But the things people move to Wellington for — the south coast in a swell, a trailhead in the Remutakas, Martinborough on a Saturday, the ferry terminal at seven in the morning — mostly need a vehicle. Many households here run one car between two adults rather than none or two.

You can skip the car if

You live in Newtown, Mount Cook, Mount Victoria, Aro Valley or Te Aro.

You work at the regional hospital and are happy to walk or cycle.

You're on a rail line and your shifts fit the timetable.

You're willing to rent or borrow for the occasional weekend trip.

You'll want one if

You work nights, and the timetable thins out when you finish.

You live in Karori, Brooklyn, Miramar or anywhere hilly off a main route.

You have children, sports bags and a school run to manage.

Weekends in the Wairarapa, the coast or the ranges are the point of moving.

Night shifts are the deciding factor for most people. Services run late but thin considerably after midnight, and a 3am finish isn't a public transport journey. If your roster includes nights, plan for a car, a taxi budget, or a suburb you can genuinely walk home from. It's the thing new arrivals most often get wrong.

Six ways around a small city

Wellington has more genuine transport options than anywhere else in the country, mostly because the geography left no room to build motorways through it.

Walking

The most Wellington answer. The CBD is about two kilometres end to end, and Newtown to the city is a twenty-five minute walk along a flat road. Invest in a proper coat rather than an umbrella – the wind destroys them within a fortnight, and locals find them mildly funny.

Trains

Four suburban lines converge on Wellington Station at the north end of the CBD – the best commuter rail network in New Zealand, and the reason the valley and northern suburbs are viable. Frequent at peak, sparser off-peak. Check the timetable against your actual roster, not the advertised frequency.

Buses

The network that actually reaches the hills. Metlink runs the whole region, and the routes through Newtown and the hospital are among the busiest in the city. Reliability has been a live public complaint for years – locals allow more time than the app suggests.

The cable car

A genuine piece of commuter infrastructure as well as a tourist attraction. Lambton Quay to Kelburn in five minutes, and the reason the university suburb feels close to town.

The harbour ferry

Queens Wharf to Days Bay and Seatoun. Slower than driving and infinitely more pleasant, and the reason some people live on the eastern bays.

Cycling

Improving quickly, and e-bikes have changed what the hills mean. The waterfront route is flat and good; the hill suburbs are for the committed.

The four rail lines

If you're choosing a suburb for a car-free life, this is the map that matters.

FOUR LINES OUT OF WELLINGTON STATION

Hutt Valley Line

The busiest line, and the one that makes the valley a realistic option for hospital staff.

Wellington Petone Lower Hutt Upper Hutt

Kāpiti Line Fast, frequent, and the reason the Kāpiti Coast is a commute rather than a move.

Wellington Porirua Paraparaumu Waikanae

Johnsonville Line Suburban, leafy, and a fifteen-minute run into town.

Wellington Ngaio Khandallah Johnsonville

Melling Line Limited service, but useful if you land in the right part of the valley.

Wellington Melling, central Lower Hutt

Indicative — each line has more stops than shown. Check Metlink for the full timetable, and check it against your roster rather than the advertised peak frequency.

Parking, driving and the tunnels

Four things to know

Off-street parking is a genuine amenity. Many older houses have none, and inner-suburb street parking is resident-permit and competitive. Check before you sign.

There's no motorway through the middle. Traffic funnels through a small number of routes, and an incident on one of them affects everything.

The Terrace and Mount Victoria tunnels are the pinch points. Locals plan around them the way Aucklanders plan around the bridge.

Hill driving in winter is narrow, wet and steep. Nothing dramatic, but a small car with good tyres beats a large one.

Leaving the city

HOW FAR AWAY EVERYTHING IS

Travel time from the city, to scale against each other. The airport is the outlier that makes Wellington feel small; the road north is the one that reminds you the country is long.

The airport

One of the most convenient in the country – but the runway is short, so international flights reach Australia and the Pacific only.



Over the Remutakas

The Wairarapa – vineyards, farmland and a slower weekend. The hill road is winding and closes occasionally in high wind.



Palmerston North

North by road, and the first city of any size on the way up.



The Interislander to Picton

Take the car. One of the great ferry crossings anywhere – and cancelled in a strong southerly.



Taupō

The middle of the North Island, and a realistic long-weekend drive.



Auckland

Driving it once is part of living here. Most people fly it after



that.

Food, coffee & the everyday

Wellington Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

New Zealand's coffee culture started here and the city has never got over it. More cafés and bars per head than New York, in a place you can walk across.

The city that taught New Zealand to drink coffee

In the late 1980s a handful of Wellington roasters started taking espresso seriously, and the habit spread outward from here to the rest of the country. The roastery names are local institutions, and most cafés will tell you whose beans they pull without being asked.

The practical consequence for you is that mediocre coffee is genuinely hard to find, and that your morning flat white becomes a small daily pleasure rather than a transaction. It also means Wellingtonians are insufferable about it, and you'll become one within about four months.

THE CLAIM, AND IT HOLDS UP

300+

CAFÉS, BARS AND RESTAURANTS IN THE CENTRE

More per head than New York, inside a centre you can walk across in twenty minutes. It is why a flat white here is a daily pleasure rather than a transaction — and why nobody in this city will let you drink a bad one quietly.

1980s

When the roasteries started

NZ\$5.50

A flat white, roughly

1 hr 15

To the Martinborough vineyards

The vocabulary, so your first order goes smoothly

Not a joke section. The words genuinely differ from the UK, the US and the Gulf, and getting them right on day one saves a small daily awkwardness.

Flat white

Espresso with steamed milk, less foam than a latte, in a smaller cup. The default order.

Long black

Closest to an Americano — espresso poured over hot water, in that order.

Short black

An espresso. Ask for a double if you want a double.

Trim

Skim milk. "Trim flat white" is a complete order.

Fluffy

Warm frothed milk with chocolate dust, for small children. Usually free.

Takeaway

Not "to go". Bring your own cup and you'll usually get a small discount.

Three local habits

Bring your own cup. A reusable cup is completely normal here and usually earns a discount. Some cafés run cup-lending schemes. It's the local default rather than a statement.

No tipping. Hospitality staff are paid a proper wage and tipping isn't expected anywhere — cafés, restaurants or taxis.

Kitchens close early. Cafés often stop serving food mid-afternoon, and many kitchens close by nine. If you finish a late shift hungry, learn which places serve late before you need them.

Six parts of the city, six different evenings

Districts rather than individual restaurants — places change, and Sophie's own list is coming. This is what each part of town is for.

Cuba Street

The heart of it. Independent, scruffy, excellent — bars, cheap eats, live music and the best people-watching in the country. Go for a long evening that starts without a plan.

Courtenay Place

Louder and later. Theatres at one end, bars along the length, and where the city goes after a show. Go for a Friday.

The waterfront & Queens Wharf

Harbour-edge dining and the walk home along the water. Go for a summer evening or when family visit.

Newtown

The most diverse eating in Wellington — Ethiopian, Malaysian, Middle Eastern, and the grocers that supply them. Go for something you can't get anywhere else.

Hannahs Laneway

A short lane of small producers — chocolate, coffee roasting, cheese. Go on a Saturday morning.

The Hutt & Petone

Jackson Street's strip of cafés and restaurants, and increasingly where the interesting new places open. Go when you want somewhere the city hasn't found yet.

Awaiting Sophie's list

Named recommendations are coming. We'd rather run her actual list — specific cafés, bars and the walk to do after Sunday brunch — than a generic top ten scraped from a review site.

Groceries and markets

The supermarkets

Pak'nSave for the bulk shop, New World for the fresh counters, Woolworths for delivery. The same two groups as the rest of the country — see [the Auckland chapter](#) for how they differ.

Harbourside Market

Sunday mornings by Te Papa. Produce, fish and coffee, and the closest thing the city has to a weekly ritual.

Newtown & Kilbirnie

Specialist grocers for South Asian, Middle Eastern, East Asian and Pacific ingredients, usually cheaper than the chains for anything you buy in quantity.

Moore Wilson's

The wholesaler the city's chefs use, open to everyone. Worth one trip just to see the scale of it.

Wine country, an hour away

Over the Remutaka Hill sits the Wairarapa, and at its centre Martinborough — a village surrounded by vineyards, small enough to cycle between them in an afternoon.

Martinborough

An hour and fifteen minutes by car, or the train to Featherston and a short hop. Pinot noir, cellar doors within cycling distance of the square, and the classic Wellington weekend.

Greytown & Carterton

On the way. Bakeries, antiques and a slower afternoon than you planned.

Marlborough

Three hours by ferry across the strait. A serious wine region and a good long weekend.

Harbour, hills & the outdoors

Wellington Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

Bush tracks fifteen minutes from most front doors, a wild coast facing Antarctica, and a predator-free valley in the middle of the city. This is what the short commute is for.

A capital city where you get woken by a parrot

Zealandia is a fenced, predator-free sanctuary in a valley in the middle of Wellington — 225 hectares of regenerating forest where rats, stoats and possums have been eradicated. Native birds were reintroduced, and then they did something nobody fully planned for: they spread out into the city.

Kākā — large, loud, intelligent forest parrots — now nest in suburban trees and shout from rooftops at dawn. Tūi and kererū are everywhere. Suburbs run their own trapping groups, and it's entirely normal for a neighbour to ask whether you want a rat trap for your garden.

It's one of the genuinely distinctive things about living here, and it's the reason a walk through the town belt sounds nothing like a park anywhere else.

Kākā

Large olive-brown parrots with a flash of red under the wing. Raucous at dawn and dusk, and increasingly common in the suburbs.

Tūi

Iridescent black with a white throat tuft. An extraordinary range of clicks, chimes and whistles — some of it beyond human hearing.

Kererū

A wood pigeon the size of a small cat. You'll hear the wingbeats before you see it, and it will eventually fall out of a tree.

Kiwi, at night

Zealandia runs guided evening tours where you can see and hear kiwi genuinely in the wild, ten minutes from the CBD. The thing to take visiting family to.

Two coasts, and one of them is dangerous

Wellington has a sheltered harbour side and an exposed southern side, and the difference matters for your safety rather than just your comfort. The harbour is calm, warmer and where families swim. The south coast faces Cook Strait, with strong currents, cold water and surf that arrives fast.

New Zealand's drowning rate is high for a developed country, and a disproportionate share involves people newly arrived who underestimated the water. This isn't a scare paragraph — it's the single most useful safety thing in this guide.

TWO COASTS, TWO SETS OF RULES

Which side of the city you swim on matters more than the temperature. The harbour is where families go; the south coast faces Cook Strait and asks something of you.

The harbour side — calm

Oriental Bay

A city beach a ten-minute walk from the CBD. Calm, warmer than the coast, and where the whole city swims in February.

Days Bay

Reachable by ferry, which makes the trip half the point. Sheltered, family-friendly, with a wharf to jump off.

The south coast — treat with respect

Lyall Bay

The surf beach, right beside the airport. Cold, exposed, and good waves. Check conditions before you go in.

Island Bay

More sheltered than Lyall by a good margin, with a marine reserve alongside. Still the south coast — treat it with respect.

Strong currents, cold water and surf that arrives fast are south-coast facts, not south-coast warnings. The panel below is the practical version.

Before your first south-coast swim

Swim between the flags where there are any. On the south coast, patrols are limited and seasonal.

Learn to spot a rip — calmer, darker, flatter water between breaking waves is the current heading out, not the safe bit.

Caught in one, don't fight it. Float, raise an arm, let it carry you out until it weakens, then swim parallel to shore.

Never swim alone on the south coast, whatever your ability. Check safeswim.org.nz (<https://safeswim.org.nz>) before you drive out.

When you've got an hour, or a day

An hour · the town belt

Bush tracks from almost any inner suburb. Mount Victoria for the harbour view, the Botanic Garden for the easy version, Polhill for something steeper.

Half a day · the south coast

Red Rocks to the seal colony — an hour's walk each way along the shore, with fur seals hauled out from May to October.

Half a day · Zealandia

Ten minutes from town. Two hours of walking, or a whole afternoon if the birds are cooperating.

A day · the Remutakas or Ōtaki

Proper tramping within an hour. Ridge lines, huts, and views back over the strait.

A day · the Wairarapa

Over the hill for vineyards, Castlepoint lighthouse, or Cape Palliser and the seal colony at the bottom of the North Island.

A weekend · the Marlborough Sounds

Three hours on the ferry and you're somewhere that feels like a different country. The crossing is worth doing at least once in good weather.

When it's horizontal

Some weekends the weather simply wins. Wellington is unusually good at this, because a small city with a capital's institutions means a lot of indoors worth going to.

Te Papa

The national museum, free, on the waterfront, and excellent. Locals go repeatedly rather than once.

Theatre & live music

More per head than anywhere else in the country. Circa, BATS and the Opera House, plus small venues most nights of the week.

The film scene

A serious production industry sits in Miramar, and the city takes cinema seriously — independent screens, festivals and a long season.

A long lunch

The most Wellington answer of all. Somewhere on Cuba Street, three hours, and the weather is somebody else's problem.